Wales Africa Partnership Research: Reflection Guide

Introduction

This guide is designed to support an ongoing process of reflection, following the conclusion of research conducted by Dr Elaine Christian in 2024, into the partnership model used by Dolen Cymru Lesotho.

This model was defined as one based on equal (or balanced) involvement: all link partners join together in friendship based on common work in promoting civic action and solidarity. Each partner is as involved in promoting equality and advancing progress in health, education, etc. in their own locality as in their partner's. This is in contrast to the partnership models frequently found in other international NGOs, particularly the "funding-implementing" partnership model, where one partner funds and directs projects that are implemented exclusively by the other partner, without any parallel action taking place in the funder's location.

The principal research questions were:

1. Does the "Dolen model" contribute to effective and equal partnership working, compared to other models? If so, how? and can these contributing factors be built on further?
2. What implications from (1) are there for Dolen, volunteers, and partners (e.g. in terms of organisational structure, approaches to partnership working, or link activities)?
3. What potential implications from (1) are there for the wider Wales Africa community?
4. For both Dolen and the wider Wales Africa community: through the lens of Solidarity and the intentions of the Wales Africa Anti-Racism Charter, what lessons can be learned from investigating the effectiveness of partnership working, both Dolen's model and other similar models identified in literature? What can be avoided, replicated, or adapted in order to contribute to increased Global Solidarity and the role of Wales as an outward looking nation?

This guide is intended to support reflection on questions 2 and 4 particularly, with a view to incorporating ongoing self-evaluation and learning for Dolen staff, board members, partners, and volunteers. However it can be used by other organisations to support reflection on question 3; or adapted for reflection on other evaluations or research findings.

Practical information

This guide assumes that the reader is familiar with research findings. The final report can be found here [link], and the executive summary is available in Sesotho [link] and Welsh [link].

These reflections can be done both collaboratively and individually; by Dolen staff members, board members, volunteers, and those leading or contributing to specific partnerships. It is highly recommended that each individual should take notes throughout the exercise. These can be written or audio notes, but for each question asked, record your reflections carefully.

A worksheet has been attached to the end of this document which can be used as a handout to record notes. You may also like to make a table or spreadsheet to collate reflections, especially from groups.

Goals for reflection

The main objective of this reflection is to understand implications arising from research findings, and to draw out answers to questions including:

1. What does the research tell you about Dolen's strengths? How do you think these could be built on further?

- What does this report tell you about Dolen's weaknesses, or areas for improvement? What changes would be necessary to improve these?
- How does this research contribute to a better understanding of the role of partnership work in promoting global solidarity? How does the way in which you work affect the work being done by links or partnerships?
- Looking at this research through the lens of the Wales-Africa Anti-Racism Charter, what areas for learning emerge? What would contribute to the role of Wales as an outward-looking nation?

Reflection Exercises

Consider each question in Section . As you do, identify any areas for potential changes to be made. Try to think of three types of changes:

- Areas of strength, to be firmed up or expanded on
- Areas of weakness, to be improved
- New approaches to be engaged (whether helpful approaches or strategies which you aren't yet doing, or counterproductive or harmful approaches or habits which can be ended, or perhaps a type of lateral movement).

For each area of change you identify, consider these aspects:

- ***Who*** is responsible or able to bring about these changes? Who can support you, or whose buy-in do you need?
- ***What*** is it that needs to change (e.g. specific approaches, behaviours, policies)?
- ***Where*** (or in what domains/contexts – e.g. organisational structure, approaches to partnership working) can changes be implemented?
- ***When*** do changes need to occur? Do they rely on any prior conditions being met, or do other aspects of change depend on them?
- ***Why*** is this change necessary or beneficial? What could happen if it doesn't change? What could happen if it does?
- ***How*** will this change be implemented? By what mechanisms will it contribute to better understanding or practice? How can we support Dolen partners and other members of the Wales-Africa community as they work toward more equitable and effective partnership working?

Further Information

This guide was developed by Dr Elaine Christian. For further information or clarification, please visit www.elainechristian.com or contact me at elaine.christian@gmail.com.

Worksheet – Reflecting on Changes

What is the change you are reflecting on? What is the broader context, or what made you think about this? Does it involve a strength, a weakness, or a new approach?

Who is responsible/able to bring about this change? Who can support you? Whose buy-in do you need?

What is it that needs to change (e.g. specific approaches, behaviours, policies)?

Where (or in what domains/contexts – e.g. organisational structure, approaches to partnership working) can the change be implemented?

When does the change need to occur? Does it rely on any prior conditions being met, or do other aspects of change depend on it?

Why is this change necessary or beneficial? What could happen if it doesn't change? What could happen if it does?

How will this change be implemented? By what mechanisms will it contribute to better understanding or practice? How can we support Dolen partners and other members of the Wales-Africa community as they work toward more equitable and effective partnership working?

Any further thoughts you wish to record: